The Bitcoin Estate Playbook

A principled handbook for holding, securing, and passing on Bitcoin within a family estate.

For families building wealth that is meant to last.

A SCHELLING POINT HANDBOOK

Contents

CHAPTER ONE

Bitcoin as a Unique Asset

A new form of property, and why it does not behave like the assets a family already knows.

Bitcoin is not simply another investment to be weighed alongside stocks and funds. It is a new form of property, one that a family can hold directly, without depending on a bank, a government, or any financial intermediary to grant or guard access to it.

What makes this possible is that ownership of Bitcoin is established through cryptographic keys rather than through an account held in your name at an institution. Whoever controls the keys controls the Bitcoin, and no one else can move it. In this respect Bitcoin has more in common with holding physical gold or land than with holding money in a bank, since the asset is genuinely in your possession rather than recorded as a claim against someone else. Yet it also differs from gold and land in ways that matter a great deal for a family thinking in decades.

Bitcoin is digital, which allows it to be held and moved anywhere in the world without the logistics that physical wealth demands. It is scarce, with a supply fixed permanently at twenty-one million coins, so that no authority can dilute it by creating more. It is global, settling on a network that anyone may use without permission. And it is sovereign, in the sense that an individual or a family can hold it directly, in their own keeping, answerable to no custodian.

Because of these properties, Bitcoin tends to occupy a different place in a family's affairs than most traditional holdings. Many families regard it much as earlier generations regarded gold, as a long-term reserve held with the intention of preserving purchasing power across many years and through conditions that erode other forms of savings. At the same time, Bitcoin continues to develop as a global monetary network in its own right, one that supports payments, savings, and the movement of capital across borders. It may therefore come to serve both as a store of value and as the foundation of a newer financial system, and it is rare for a single asset to carry both possibilities at once.

For a family, this combination raises questions that ordinary investments rarely prompt, and they are the questions this playbook exists to help you answer. How should Bitcoin be secured, not for a season but for decades? How should it pass from one generation to the next? How should a family hold its nerve through the price movements that come with a young asset? When is it wise to keep Bitcoin, and when to deploy it into other things? And how can it be protected closely while remaining within reach of the people who will one day need it? These are not merely technical matters. They are the substance of holding this particular asset well, and we will take them in turn.

CHAPTER TWO

Bitcoin Within an Estate

Where Bitcoin sits among the things a family already holds, and what it complements.

When a family builds wealth that is meant to last, its holdings are rarely of a single kind. They are spread across several categories, each serving a different purpose, so that some assets generate income, others preserve value over time, and others can be turned into cash at short notice when the family needs liquidity. Every kind of asset carries its own advantages and its own limitations, which is precisely why a thoughtfully built estate holds a mixture of them rather than relying on any one. Land cannot be moved or quickly sold, cash loses value to inflation, and shares rise and fall with the fortunes of the companies beneath them. A family holds several things at once because no single thing does everything well.

It helps to picture a family's assets along a spectrum, running from the most physical to the most digital. At one end sits land, then property built upon it, then gold, each of them tangible and rooted in a place. Further along sit shares and the deposits held in a bank, which are no longer physical objects but entries in someone else's ledger. At the far end sits Bitcoin, which is fully digital and yet, unlike a bank deposit, is held directly by its owner rather than recorded as a claim against an institution. Understanding where Bitcoin lies on this spectrum is the first step to understanding the role it can play.

What sets Bitcoin apart

Bitcoin brings together a set of qualities that are seldom found together in a single asset, and it is this combination, rather than any one feature on its own, that gives it its particular place in an estate.

It is unusually liquid and simple to move. Bitcoin can be bought or sold almost anywhere in the world and at almost any hour, through active markets that never fully close, so that a family can convert it into local currency or into other assets whenever the need arises. It is also owned without anyone's permission, since Bitcoin can be acquired, held, and transferred without the approval of a bank, a broker, or a government office. Because it exists only as digital information, it can be moved across borders quickly and discreetly, and considerable wealth can be carried or transferred without the practical burdens that physical assets impose or the restrictions that come with anything held inside a bank.

Its reach continues to widen. Bitcoin is increasingly used for payments and savings, and is held as a reserve asset not only by individuals but by companies and, in a small but growing number of cases, by governments. It is also seen as a pristine form of capital. Because of its liquidity, its digital nature, and its programmability as a bearer asset, Bitcoin is increasingly used as collateral to borrow against. Families employ this strategy to reduce the tax burden that arises from capital gains, drawing on the value of their holding without having to sell it. Bitcoin also offers a measure of financial privacy, because a holding kept in one's own custody is not automatically visible to financial institutions or recorded in public registries, which allows a family that follows sound security practices to manage its affairs with discretion.

Why Bitcoin can belong in a modern estate

For these reasons, a growing number of families choose to hold Bitcoin as a long-term reserve within their wider estate, where it can sit alongside their traditional holdings and complement them. It offers a store of value that is at the same time highly liquid, a form of wealth that can be moved across the world directly and without intermediaries, and a return profile that has historically borne little relation to that of conventional markets.

Yet the very qualities that make Bitcoin valuable are the same qualities that demand care in holding it. Because ownership rests entirely on cryptographic keys, the security of those keys over the long term, and the question of how they will pass to the next generation, can be a hard problem to solve. The chapters that follow set out, step by step, how a family can build that structure with confidence, both on a technical level and in the communication between family members that is needed to conserve the wealth and to help in the building of it.

CHAPTER THREE

What Is an Estate

Why families build them, and what they are truly meant to protect.

An estate is everything a family owns and is responsible for, gathered into a single picture: the home and any land, a business if there is one, savings and investments, and increasingly digital holdings such as Bitcoin. Its purpose runs deeper than the list, though. An estate is the structure that allows what a family has built to outlive any one member of it, passing intact from those who created it to those who come after.

That is why families have built estates for as long as they have had anything worth keeping. The aim has always been to carry something forward, so that the next generation begins from the foundation the last one laid rather than from nothing.

A well-ordered estate does a few things at once. It protects what the family holds against the ordinary hazards of life and the wider hazards of the world. It provides continuity, so that if the person who has managed everything falls ill or is suddenly gone, others can step in without confusion or loss. And it allows for an orderly handing-on, so that wealth reaches the next generation deliberately, sparing the family the accidents and disputes that so often accompany an estate left unplanned.

Capital exists to serve the family

It is worth stating plainly the principle that ought to sit beneath all of this. Financial capital exists to serve people. A family's true wealth lies as much in its people as in its assets: in their character and abilities, and in the knowledge, values, and judgement handed from one generation to the next. Money is at its most useful when it supports those things, giving people the means to develop their talents, pursue work that matters to them, and meet their responsibilities to those who follow.

Seen this way, the purpose of an estate is the flourishing of the family the wealth is there to support. This is the lens we bring to every part of the work, and it is the reason a Bitcoin plan, in our view, is always more than a technical exercise.

Why estates are difficult to preserve

If building an estate were easy to sustain, every fortune would last for centuries, and few do. Wealth is worn away over time by forces a family cannot fully control: by inflation and financial crises that erode the value of savings; by changes in law, taxation, and policy that alter what can be owned and how it passes on; and, in harder histories, by conflict and upheaval that have separated many families from what they held. The internal pressures are just as real. An estate can be undone from within, through decisions made without coordination, or through wealth that fragments and loses its meaning as it divides across a growing family who never shared an understanding of it.

The families whose wealth endures are those who plan as though change is certain, because it is. They build with the expectation that conditions will shift and that their resources will always face some pressure, and they prepare for it deliberately rather than trusting that things will hold. Bitcoin, well held, can be a remarkable instrument for exactly this kind of family. Holding it well is what the rest of this book is about.

CHAPTER FOUR

How to Use This Playbook

What this book is for, and the one truth to carry through all of it.

This playbook is written for families who hold Bitcoin in their own custody and who want it to form part of an estate that lasts. The earlier chapters explained why Bitcoin earns a place in a serious family's affairs. This one is shorter, and its task is to set out what the rest of the book will give you, and how to get the most from it.

By the end, you should be able to do five things with confidence. The first is to understand what controls your Bitcoin: what your keys are, what they look like in practice, and why your entire holding rests on them, so that loss, theft, and ordinary mistakes become risks you can manage. The second is to record and store your recovery words safely, knowing how many copies to keep and where, and with whom, to place them, so they survive accident, theft, and the passage of years. The third is to avoid depending on any single person or place, since most Bitcoin is lost to concentration rather than to attackers. The fourth is to give your family a plan they can actually use if illness, accident, or death takes you out of the picture, so that the people you trust are never left guessing. And the fifth is to prepare the next generation to hold what they inherit with the same care you brought to building it, passing on the understanding along with the asset.

Read it in order

Each chapter rests on the one before it, and Bitcoin is far easier to hold well once it is understood step by step. The later chapters introduce more capable tools, and they will make sense once the foundations are in place. The early chapters are short, and they repay an unhurried reading.

One truth, stated plainly

Bitcoin has no customer support desk. If your recovery words are lost, no one can restore them, and if your family cannot find them or does not know how to use them, the Bitcoin may never reach them. We say this plainly because the entire purpose of what follows is to build a system that keeps your Bitcoin safe while remaining usable by the people you trust.

A word on how we work

A book can set out principles, but it cannot sit across the table from you and weigh them against your particular circumstances. That is the role Schelling Point plays. Families come to us as the trusted party they can speak to about anything concerning their Bitcoin, from the first decisions about custody to the conversations that prepare an heir. Read this playbook as the foundation of that relationship: the shared vocabulary and the settled principles, so that the time we spend together is spent on the questions that are truly yours.

CHAPTER FIVE

Why Bitcoin Estates Fail

The handful of ways things go wrong, and what each one teaches us.

Holding Bitcoin directly gives a family a rare degree of control over its own wealth, with no bank or broker standing in the way. That same control carries a responsibility, because the person who holds the keys holds the Bitcoin, and the arrangement that keeps it safest during a lifetime is often the one that makes it hardest for anyone else to reach.

This is the central tension of a Bitcoin estate. A holding must stay secure while its owner is alive and well, and it must become accessible to the right people at the moment they need it, which is usually the moment the owner can no longer help them. Balancing those two demands is the real work, and when the balance is left to chance, estates fail in a small number of recognisable ways. Most of those failures concern access: whether the Bitcoin can still be reached by the right people. Four of them appear again and again.

Custody risk

The first is handing control to someone else. When a family leaves its Bitcoin with an exchange or a custodian, it gives up the very thing that made the asset worth holding, because access now depends on that institution remaining solvent, secure, and willing to release the funds. History offers a long and repeating list of cases where that trust was misplaced and clients lost everything. Convenience at the start becomes exposure for as long as the arrangement lasts.

Do-it-yourself fragility

The second is over-engineering. Some owners, determined to solve inheritance alone, build elaborate schemes of split phrases, hidden instructions, and switches meant to trigger after a period of silence. These designs can be clever, and their cleverness is the problem, because complexity is fragile. Software stops being maintained, a single instruction proves unclear, and one small error is enough to put the funds beyond reach of the very people the scheme was built to protect.

Family confusion

The third is the most human. The Bitcoin can be secured perfectly and the keys fully recoverable, and still the estate fails because the family does not know what to do. Relatives who have never handled a wallet, a backup, or a signing device are asked to perform an unfamiliar and unforgiving task at the hardest moment of their lives, and a small misunderstanding becomes a permanent loss. A plan the family cannot follow is not a plan at all.

Single points of failure

The fourth runs through all the others. A holding that depends on one key, one device, one backup, or one location is a holding waiting to be undone by a single event: a fire, a theft, a flood, a lapse of memory. A sound structure spreads its keys, its copies, and its responsibilities so that no one mishap can take everything, and so that the loss of any single piece is an inconvenience rather than a catastrophe.

A different kind of failure

The four failures above are all variations of the same danger: losing access to the Bitcoin. There is another kind of failure that takes nothing and breaks nothing, where the keys stay secure and the family keeps full access, and the fortune still slips away. This one comes from how the holding sits within the family's wider affairs, and from the emotions that volatility stirs, and it may be the most common of all.

Bitcoin is a young asset, and its price moves in ways that test the resolve of anyone who has not understood what they are holding. The danger rarely begins with the Bitcoin itself. It begins when the rest of the family's affairs leave no room to absorb a shock: no cash buffer to meet an unexpected expense, no plan for raising liquidity when one is needed, no discipline around spending as costs rise. When that happens, the family is forced to draw down on the very holding that was meant to become a permanent part of its wealth, and often at the worst possible moment, when the price is low and the pressure is high. A great many people have drawn down what could have been generational wealth, not because they intended to, but because nothing else was in place to carry the weight, or because a difficult month made the holding feel like a fund to dip into rather than a foundation to build upon.

No backup or signing arrangement defends against this, because it is a failure of structure and temperament rather than of security. What defends against it is a steady presence beside the family, and a holding placed within a wider plan. Part of our role at Schelling Point is to help a family build the buffers and the liquidity strategies that keep the Bitcoin from ever becoming the thing that must give way, and to help them understand the asset well enough to hold it through its volatility with confidence. Our aim is for a family to come to see its Bitcoin as a permanent backbone of the patrimony, held with conviction across generations, rather than a balance to be drawn upon whenever the rest of the plan falls short. Securing the keys protects the asset; this protects the fortune.

A common root

What these failures share is that none of them was designed against. The chapters that follow take the question of access in turn and build, step by step, a structure in which each technical failure has been anticipated and answered. The failure of structure and temperament is answered differently, through planning, understanding, and the relationship a family keeps with those who advise it, and it is a thread we will return to throughout the book.

CHAPTER SIX

The First Principle of Security

Three words, held apart in the mind, that make every later decision simple.

Everything about securing Bitcoin follows from a single fact: Bitcoin is a bearer asset. Whoever holds the key controls the coins, and there is no institution behind it to reverse a mistake, restore a loss, or vouch for who the rightful owner is. A bank can claw back a wire or reissue a card. With Bitcoin, the protection is whatever you build around the key yourself. This is the whole of it, and once it is understood, the rest of this book becomes a series of sensible answers to one question: how do we protect the key.

To do that well, a family needs to hold three things apart in the mind, because they are constantly confused with one another. They are the key, the device, and the backup.

One secret, kept in two forms. The device lets you use it; the backup lets you restore it.

The key

The key is the Bitcoin. In practice it takes the form of a list of twelve or twenty-four ordinary words, generated when a wallet is first created. Whoever has those words can move the funds, from anywhere, with no further permission needed. Nothing else grants control, and nothing else can substitute for them. Every other part of the system exists only to protect this one thing.

The device

The device is the tool that holds the key and uses it. A hardware wallet, usually no larger than the palm of a hand, keeps the key sealed inside and signs transactions on your behalf without ever exposing the words to a computer or phone. The important point is that the device is replaceable. If it is lost, broken, or destroyed, the Bitcoin is safe, because the device was only ever holding a copy of the key, not the only copy. A new device can be set up from the words at any time.

The backup

The backup is simply the key written down. When a wallet is created, you record those twelve or twenty-four words by hand, on paper or, better, stamped into steel that can survive fire and flood. That written record is the backup, and it is what lets you recreate the key if every device is gone. It is the most important piece of paper a family will own, and it is also the one most often mishandled, written carelessly, stored somewhere insecure, or lost in a move. A backup that cannot be found when it is needed is the same as no backup at all.

In truth there are not three separate things here, but one secret kept in different forms. The key is the secret itself, the thing that controls the Bitcoin. The device holds that secret in sealed electronic form and uses it to sign. The backup is that same secret in physical form, written by hand so it can outlast any device. Seen this way the chain is simple: the device lets you use the key day to day, and the backup lets you recreate it if every device is gone. Keep that picture clear, and the chapters that follow, on how many backups to keep, where to place them, and how to pass them on, will each have an obvious place to sit.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Protecting Against Loss and Theft

The practical rules that prevent almost every avoidable loss, and where to keep what they protect.

With the principle in place that the whole of a holding rests on one secret kept in two forms, the practical question becomes simple to state. How should that secret be written, how many copies should exist, and where should they be kept so that they survive both the accidents of life and the attentions of anyone who should not have them? The answers are few, and they do not change with the size of the holding. A family that follows them closely has already avoided the great majority of ways Bitcoin is lost.

Never photograph the words, never type them into a connected device

The first rule has two halves, and both close off the unseen ways the secret escapes. A photograph of a recovery phrase will, in time, find its way into a cloud backup, onto a replaced phone, or into the hands of whoever repairs a laptop, and from there it is gone beyond recall. A phrase typed into anything connected to the internet, whether a notes application, a password manager, or an email to oneself, can be reached by a determined attacker. A hardware wallet is built so the words never need to leave it, and they should not. If the words have ever touched a connected device, treat them as exposed and move the funds to a freshly created key.

Write it carefully, then prove it works

A backup is only as good as its legibility on the day it is finally needed, which may be decades after it was made and by someone other than the person who wrote it. Write the words by hand, clearly, and check each one against the wallet's own list of valid words, since a single ambiguous letter can render the whole phrase a guess. Then prove the backup before trusting it, by using it to restore the wallet onto a clean device and confirming the same holding appears, after which the test device is wiped. A backup that has been verified is a backup a family can rely on; one that has never been tested is a hope.

Keep at least two copies, on lasting material

A single copy is a single point of failure, and the remedy is plain: keep at least two, and three for a larger holding. Paper is enough to begin with, but a phrase meant to last for decades belongs on something that lasts for decades, and steel plates made for the purpose are inexpensive and survive the fire or flood that would destroy paper. The cost is small against what it protects, and it removes one of the most ordinary causes of loss, which is a backup that simply degraded in a drawer.

Keep the copies in more than one place

Two copies in the same house are, in practice, one copy, because the event that destroys one will destroy the other. Copies should sit in places separated meaningfully against the dangers being guarded against: a home safe and a bank's safe deposit box, the home of a trusted relative, or an attorney's strongroom. Two locations is the minimum that means anything, and the right distance between them depends on what the family is protecting against, since a second site across the city defends against a house fire while a second site in another region defends against a flood or a storm that takes a whole area at once.

Reach the copies without exposing them

The final consideration is that each place must be reachable by the right people at the right time, without lying open to the wrong ones. A bank's safe deposit box is secure but slow, and may be hard for a grieving family to open quickly. A copy at a relative's home is quick to reach but only as private as that relative is careful. A sound arrangement spreads these qualities across its locations rather than asking any one of them to be fast, private, and durable all at once, and it records, somewhere the family can find it, what is kept where and who may retrieve it.

None of these rules is difficult, and that is the point. Almost every loss attributed to bad luck turns out, on inspection, to have broken one of them. Followed together, they turn the most fragile part of a Bitcoin holding into its most dependable, and they are the foundation on which the inheritance arrangements in the chapters that follow are built.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Ways to Hold

From a single key to shared control, and how to choose the arrangement that fits the family.

A family that has understood the key, and the rules that protect it, is ready for the question that shapes everything afterwards: how many keys should stand between the holding and the people who control it, and in whose hands should they sit. This is the question of custody, and there is no single right answer to it. The right arrangement depends on the size of the holding, the confidence of the people involved, and how much a family wishes to lean on others. What follows are the arrangements worth knowing, set out from the simplest to the most considered.

A single key

The simplest arrangement is one key, held by one person, protected by the rules of the last chapter. For a modest holding in steady hands it can be enough, and its virtue is that nothing about it is hard to understand. Its weakness is the same as its strength, because everything rests on that one key and the discipline of the person who keeps it. A single key suits a spending balance or an early holding. It is rarely the right home for wealth a family intends to keep for a generation.

A single key with a passphrase

A step up in strength, without a step up in the number of keys, is to add a passphrase: a secret word or phrase that combines with the recovery words to reach the holding. The written backup alone is then no longer enough, since whoever finds it still lacks the passphrase held in the owner's memory or in a separate place. This adds real protection against a stolen or discovered backup, and it adds an equal measure of danger, because a passphrase that is forgotten or lost takes the holding with it. We return to passphrases in the next chapter, where they belong, because they ask more of a family than they first appear to.

Collaborative custody, or multisig

The most considered arrangement replaces the single key with a small set, most often three, and requires more than one of them to approve any movement of funds. The common form is two-of-three: three keys exist, any two together can move the holding, and no single key can do so alone. This one change answers a whole class of dangers at once. A lost key no longer loses the holding, because the remaining two can recover it. A stolen key no longer steals it, because the thief still needs a second. And no single person, whether under pressure or acting alone, can move the funds without another's agreement.

The cost of this strength is that there is more to hold and more to coordinate: three keys, three backups, three places, and a small configuration file that records how the keys fit together, which the family will need in order to recover the wallet. Held carelessly, this complexity becomes its own risk. Held well, it is the structure on which a serious family holding rests, and it is the natural home for a vault meant to last.

Where Schelling Point sits in this

A natural question is where an advisor fits into an arrangement like this. Our answer is deliberate, and it is a line we do not cross: Schelling Point never holds a key, never co-signs, and never takes custody of any part of a family's Bitcoin. The keys are yours, and they remain wholly in your hands and those of the people you choose.

Our role sits beside the structure rather than inside it. We help a family decide which arrangement suits its holding, design a collaborative custody setup and choose who should hold each key, and think through where those keys should live and how they should pass on. When the time comes, we help an heir understand what they are looking at and what to do next. The keys that move the Bitcoin belong to the family alone; what we provide is the judgement, the structure, and the steady guidance around them. We are advisors in the long-term management of a family's capital, not a holder of it, and keeping that distinction clear is part of how we keep a family's sovereignty intact.

CHAPTER NINE

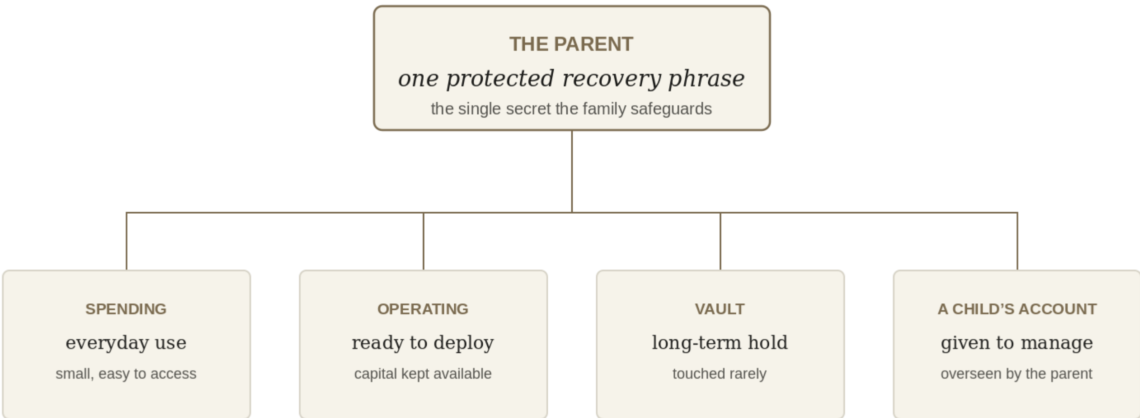
Accounts, Branches, and Passphrases

How one key can give rise to many, and how a single added word changes everything.

Two ideas allow a family to shape a holding to its needs rather than accept whatever a wallet gives it by default. The first is that a single key can give rise to many. The second is that a single added word can place part of a holding behind a hidden door. Both are useful, and both reward being understood before they are used.

One parent, many accounts

It surprises most people to learn that the twelve or twenty-four words of a recovery phrase do not stand for a single pool of Bitcoin, but for a whole tree of separate accounts, all growing from that one root and all recoverable from it. The root is the parent. Everything beneath it is derived from the parent in a fixed, repeatable way, which is why a single backup of those words restores the entire structure at once, every account together.



All accounts grow from one parent, and all are restored from its single backup.

For a family, the value of this is order. From one well-protected parent seed phrase, a holding can be divided into distinct accounts governed by other seed phrases, each holding its own funds and serving its own purpose: an account for everyday spending, an account for capital kept ready to deploy, an account held as the long-term vault for your children, and so on. Each behaves as a separate wallet, watched and managed on its own, yet all of them rest on the same protected parent seed phrase and the same disciplined backup. A family gains the clarity of many wallets while having one secret to safeguard that can back the rest of them, which is a rare and welcome combination.

There is a further step available to families who want it. Because every account descends from the parent, a single account can be handed to a particular family member to use and watch as their own, while the parent retains the ability to oversee and, if ever needed, to recover the whole. A parent can give an adult child their own account to manage, learn from, and take responsibility for, without surrendering the root that ties the family's holding together. Used in a deliberate manner, this turns the structure into something more than safekeeping. It becomes a way to bring the next generation into the holding gradually, with real responsibility but within a structure the family still stands behind.

The passphrase

A passphrase is an additional secret, chosen by the owner, that combines with the recovery words to reach a holding. Its effect runs in both directions, and that is the whole of its character. With the right passphrase, a wallet appears that the recovery words alone would never reveal. Without it, that wallet does not appear to exist at all.

What it solves is the danger of a discovered backup. A recovery phrase found in a drawer, a safe, or a will is useless to whoever finds it if a passphrase is still required, and the passphrase lives somewhere else entirely, in memory or in a separately guarded place. For a family worried that a backup might fall into the wrong hands, this is a genuine strengthening.

The risk also increases in losing access to it. A passphrase forgotten is a holding lost, with no recourse of any kind, and passphrases are forgotten far more often than people expect. A passphrase written down carelessly has the same repercussions as if you have mishandled your main seed phrase. A passphrase known to one person alone disappears with that person, and a passphrase shared too widely protects nothing. The most common cause of a permanently lost passphrase holding is not theft or disaster. It is the owner not documenting it correctly.

For this reason a passphrase suits the family that understands precisely the risk they are taking on, and has a deliberate plan for how the passphrase will be remembered, recorded, and one day passed on. Used so, it is a powerful protection. If the passphrase is used in a casual manner, it will increase risk of loss. Where a family chooses to use one, the instructions are simple: write it down, keep it apart from the recovery words and with the same care, tell only those who will truly need it, confirm that the holding is able to be restored from the words and the passphrase together, and treat the passphrase, in every respect, as part of the inheritance.

CHAPTER TEN

Keeping the Plan Alive

A Bitcoin estate is not built once. It is kept, exercised, and handed on.

The arrangements in this book are not the kind a family sets up once and forgets. Devices age, people move, children grow, take on responsibility, and a plan that was sound three years ago can fall out of step with the lives it was meant to serve. What keeps a Bitcoin estate dependable & relevant is not a single action during setup but a habit of tending it regularly. A family that practises its plan will hold its nerve and its Bitcoin through the moments that undo families who only filed theirs away and didn't look at it again.

Exercise the plan before you need it

The only way to know that a plan works is to use it while nothing is at stake. A family does well to rehearse the ordinary motions until they are familiar: setting up a device and recovering a wallet from its backup onto a clean device to confirm the words are right, sending and receiving small amounts so that the mechanics of using it does not instill any fear, and working through the steps an heir would one day have to follow, performed by the heir rather than the owner. These drills cost little and reveal a great deal, since the situation where someone hesitates while practicing, can be addressed so when the real day comes, it's muscle memory and stress levels are kept at a low.

Keep a checklist, and keep it current

Much of what protects a holding is simply remembering to check it. A short checklist, worked through once a year, keeps the estate honest: that each device still powers on and signs; that each backup is where the records say it is and is still legible; that the people named as helpers and heirs are still willing and still reachable at the numbers held for them; that the written instructions still describe the setup as it actually stands; and that the year's life events, a birth, a marriage, a move, a death, have been accounted for. Recording the date of each review, and what changed, turns the estate into a more secure, certain and constant asset that is immediately deployable, useful and a safety net the whole family can rely on.

Meet, and talk about it

The part most often neglected is also the most human. A Bitcoin estate is held not only in devices and backups but in the understanding shared among the people who will one day rely on it, and that understanding is built through conversation. A family is well served by setting aside time, perhaps once a year on a calm day, to talk through its Bitcoin estate together. The agenda does not need to be technical. It is enough to revisit what exists and where, to let those who will inherit ask their questions and handle the devices, to walk through what should happen if the principal holder were suddenly gone, and to place the holding in the wider context of the family's wealth and intentions. These conversations do lasting work. They turn a holding that lives in one person's head into knowledge the family shares, and they are where an heir's confidence is built long before it is called upon.

Where we come in

This is the work a family need not carry alone, and it is much of what an ongoing relationship with Schelling Point is for. We help a family keep its drills regular and its checklist current, we lead the periodic reviews and the family conversations, and we keep the structure abreast of changes in the family's life and in the tools themselves. The aim is constant: that the family's Bitcoin remains secure, understood, and ready to pass on, for as long as the family intends to hold it, which is to say for generations.

IN CLOSING

About Schelling Point

This is the firm that accompanies the family throughout their generations.

We have set out a list of principles in this playbook. A Bitcoin Estate plan is built through conversation, based on the particulars of a family's wealth, its people, its intentions, and its knowledge, and that is what we assess and the work we do.

Schelling Point is an advisory firm devoted to one task: helping families manage their Bitcoin estate well, across generations. We guide the decisions this book describes, from the first questions of custody to the structures of how to hold it, the preparation of heirs, and the lengthy discipline of managing Bitcoin as capital. We refuse to hold a family's keys and we never take custody of their Bitcoin. We want the family to maintain their sovereignty throughout their time on earth. We want them to always have the option to cease the relationship with Schelling Point and still remain in full control, yet they still choose to have us by their side. We provide judgement, structure, and a steady hand beside you for as long as you intend to hold.

A family's Bitcoin is more than a holding. Held and managed well, understood by the people who will inherit it, it becomes a permanent foundation of the family's wealth and legacy, carried from one generation to the next with intention. If that is something you want to build, we would be glad to begin a conversation with you.

Schelling Point · charlie@schellingpoint.xyz · schellingpoint.xyz